

TRAN's consensus on CO2 standards

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Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By TOMMASO LECCA with JORDYN DAHL SNEAK PEEK — Consensus is building in the TRA

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with JORDYN DAHL

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SNEAK PEEK

— Consensus is building in the TRAN Committee around what emissions target automakers should reach in 2035, an analysis of the committee's amendments shows.

— Synthetic aviation fuel developers are urging the Commission to uphold mandates and penalties ahead of next year's ReFuelEU Aviation review.

— Europe's car exports are falling, driven by a decline in internal combustion engine exports as consumers shift to electric vehicles.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

WHAT THE TRAN COMMITTEE WANTS FOR CO2 STANDARDS: A consensus is forming in the TRAN Committee on what flexibilities automakers should be given to meet EU emissions targets, with the committee looking at an 80 percent reduction, instead of the European Commission's proposed 90 percent. That's Jordyn's assessment after reading through all 274 pages of TRAN amendments .

Watering down emissions standards: The Commission proposed changing its 2035 de facto combustion engine ban by lowering the emissions reduction target from 100 percent to 90 percent. But automakers must offset the added emissions through things like made-in-EU green steel and alternative fuels. TRAN is giving an opinion on the CO2 issue because ENVI is the lead committee for the file. Check back later this week for Jordyn's report on all 981 of the ENVI amendments.

What Patriots want: The far-right Patriots want to get rid of the emission targets altogether, submitting an amendment deleting the 2035 emission reduction goal. The targets, the group's MEPs wrote in a justification note, "have only one purpose: to eliminate the 'car culture,' whether for motorists or the industry." A small group of Patriots MEPs, meanwhile, proposed far weaker targets of a 40 percent reduction for cars and 35 percent for vans starting in 2035.

The EPP breaks ranks: The European People's Party campaigned on overturning the 2035 regulation and is in charge of the file in both TRAN and ENVI committees. However, a smaller group of EPP MEPs — Martine Kemp of Luxembourg and the Czech Republic's Luděk Niedermayer and Jan Farský — pushed back on weakening the emission standards, especially when it comes to alternative fuels that they say need to be reserved for harder-to-decarbonize sectors like aviation and maritime. "Any adjustment should be strictly time-limited to remain aligned with the EU's 2040 and 2050 climate goals," they wrote.

Pooling for all: Under the regulation, automakers not meeting the targets can join a pool with those that overshoot them, often brands that only sell electric vehicles. But the Commission wants to reform the regulation so that automakers must choose between joining a pool or taking advantage of the green steel and alternative fuel offsets. With the exception of MEP Lena Schilling of the Greens, all of the groups put forward amendments that would allow automakers to take advantage of the offsets while still joining the pools.

Alternative dictionary: Two of the biggest points of contention are what counts as a zero-emission vehicle and what materials should be included as a potential emissions offset. The EPP, the European Conservatives and Reformists, the Patriots and Renew want only vehicles that run exclusively on alternative fuels to be considered zero-emission. All the groups except the Greens argue that low-carbon materials like aluminum should be included as an offset in addition to green steel.

Crediting system: Small EVs made in the EU count as 1.3 cars toward the emission standard. While the groups maintained the European preference requirements, each group has a different suggestion for how big the credit should be. Renew wants the credit increased to 1.5 for cars made in the EU and for all zero-emission cars — regardless of size — to be eligible for the 1.3 credit.

AVIATION

ESAF DEVELOPERS URGE BRUSSELS NOT TO WATER DOWN REFUELEU: The only way to ensure that the sustainable aviation fuel mandates under ReFuelEU Aviation are met is to keep both the targets and the penalties unchanged, the synthetic SAF sector — known as eSAF — argues ahead of next year's review of the regulation.

Quick recap: Unlike mandates for so-called bioSAF made from feedstocks such as used cooking oil, eSAF blending targets have yet to take effect. Major airlines want the 2030 mandate postponed, while large fuel suppliers have urged the Commission to review the penalties they could face if industrial-scale production is not ready by the end of the decade. After offering reassurances behind closed doors, the Commission has repeatedly insisted it has no intention of weakening the mandates.

What's the problem? Although plenty of eSAF projects have been announced across Europe, none has yet reached final investment decision for commercial-scale production.

The eSAF dilemma: "Many airlines have been circumspect on their intentions," said Dan Sutton, CEO of Iceland-based eSAF developer Syntholene Energy. "As a result, this is preventing those offtake [agreements] from taking shape," Sutton told Tommaso, noting that such contracts "are essential to get the production infrastructure built." That is why the whole debate over eSAF has become "a chicken-and-egg problem," he said.

Price issue: Airlines are also reluctant because eSAF is currently expected to cost over 10 times more than conventional jet fuel at pre-Iran-war prices. With fuel already their largest operating cost, airlines complain that the Emissions Trading System allowances available for SAF and eSAF use are still

insufficient to offset the additional burden created by ReFuelEU.

Trust the market: Sutton argues that current price estimates reflect today's scarcity rather than the long-term economics of the fuel. "The same thing happened with bioSAF," he said. Prices "were assumed to be many multiples higher than jet fuel." Once production obligations took effect, however, "the prices began to come down ... and now, we're actually facing a potential oversupply of bioSAF as early as the early 2030s."

Nordic solution: Syntholene has built a demonstration facility in Iceland and is in talks with Icelandair over future eSAF supplies. "It is a high-temperature electrolyzer combined with geothermal heat and electricity, and that drastically reduces the cost of producing electrolytic hydrogen," Sutton said, noting that "hydrogen is the key ingredient to synthetic fuels." Once commercial production begins, he believes "this fuel could be cost competitive with fossil fuels ... and decoupled from the volatility we see in crude oil."

Fines taking shape: Meanwhile, Germany is reportedly moving ahead with legislation introducing the penalties required under ReFuelEU for fuel suppliers failing to meet SAF mandates. The step follows infringement proceedings launched by the Commission in June against Germany and 12 other member countries that have yet to introduce the penalties into national law.

Under ReFuelEU, fines must amount to at least twice the average price difference between fossil jet fuel and SAF or eSAF, multiplied by the non-compliant quantity. Airlines warned that this could result in €7 billion to €9 billion of eSAF penalties being pushed onto carriers by fuel suppliers.

COMMISSION CLOSES ANTITRUST INVESTIGATION INTO PRATT & WHITNEY: The Commission has closed an antitrust investigation into turboprop aircraft engine supplier Pratt & Whitney Canada Corp. after the company changed contracts that may have hindered spare-parts suppliers. The EU executive suspected that contracts with maintenance shops in Pratt & Whitney's network restricted them from selling used engine cores or providing certification services to independent used serviceable material suppliers, our colleague Francesca Micheletti reports.

Concern addressed: The Commission said its competition concerns were addressed after Pratt & Whitney removed the restrictions and clarified that maintenance shops could buy used parts from other suppliers. The closure does not, however, amount to a finding that the conduct under investigation complied with EU competition rules.

CARS

COMBUSTION ENGINE EXPORTS CONTINUE TO DECLINE: Europe's automakers — and the German brands in particular — have long relied on exports to keep up profits. But exports have declined sharply since peaking in 2017, driven by a fall in combustion-engine vehicle sales, according to a new report from Capital Economics . Since 2017, combustion engine exports have fallen by 2.5 million vehicles.

Factory problems: The automotive sector has announced tens of thousands of layoffs, turning its economic crisis into a political one that will likely result in "factories running well below capacity and workers' hours being cut," the report's author Jack Allen-Reynolds told Jordyn in an email. "But we suspect that the long-term trend will be towards lower employment and production in Europe."

A global shift: Exports to the United States have largely stabilized since President Donald Trump slapped new tariffs on vehicles. Rather, Allen-Reynolds says the export decline is due to European automakers being "less competitive while at the same time consumers are switching towards EVs." In emerging

markets like Thailand or Brazil, EV sales are taking off, and Chinese automakers are increasingly the brands of choice.

Trade imbalance: Electric vehicle exports from Europe are increasing but “not enough to make up the gap,” Allen-Reynolds said. And EV imports from China are on the rise, even after the Commission slapped new duties on made-in-China EVs. Chinese automakers are also importing a slew of new plug-in hybrids, the report shows, which are not covered by the duties and are increasingly popular with consumers.

PIT STOPS

A strike by Norwegian air traffic controllers began Friday disrupting operations at several of the country’s largest airports.

The ban on shared e-scooters in Brussels has been delayed from September to January, while shared e-bikes will continue to circulate thanks to a deal between the regional government and operators, RTBF reports.

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